

Syracuse Metropolitan University

HCA 125 - Foundations of Health Administration

Fall 2026 | School of Health Systems & Administration

Course Information

Instructor: Dr. Camille Torres
Class Time: Tuesday / Thursday, 2:00-3:15 PM
Location: Harbor Hall 214
Office Hours: Wednesday, 11:00 AM-1:00 PM or by appointment
Email: ctorres@smu-example.edu

Course Description

HCA 125 introduces students to the structure and management of health care organizations in the United States. The course surveys hospitals, ambulatory care, long-term care, insurers, public health agencies, and community-based services while emphasizing the administrative decisions that influence access, cost, quality, workforce, and patient experience.

Learning Outcomes

- Describe the major components of the U.S. health care system and the roles of key stakeholders.
- Compare common health care organization types, reimbursement models, and administrative functions.
- Apply introductory management concepts to staffing, operations, quality improvement, and patient access.
- Interpret basic health services data and present a clear administrative recommendation.
- Recognize ethical, legal, equity, and policy considerations in health care decision-making.

Course Materials

- Selected articles, case studies, and short readings posted on the course site.
- Access to spreadsheet software for introductory budgeting and operations exercises.
- A notebook or digital note-taking system for weekly case reflections.

Grading

Weekly reading checks	10%
Participation / discussion	10%
Health system brief	20%
Operations case analysis	20%
Midterm exam	15%
Final group project	25%

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Assignments, policies, and tentative schedule

Major Assignments

Health System Brief

A 3-4 page brief on one health care organization or sector. Students explain its role in the broader system, identify major stakeholders, and discuss one current administrative challenge.

Operations Case Analysis

A written response to a fictional management case involving workflow, staffing, patient access, quality, or service delivery. Students identify the problem, use course concepts, and recommend practical next steps.

Final Group Project

Teams design an administrative improvement proposal for a fictional health care organization. The final submission includes a short report and a 10-minute presentation supported by evidence and course concepts.

Course Policies

Attendance

Students are responsible for material covered in class. If absent, review posted materials and follow up on any missed group responsibilities.

Late Work

Late work may receive reduced credit unless an extension was arranged before the deadline or circumstances warrant flexibility.

Technology

Laptops and tablets may be used for course-related work. Students should avoid sharing sensitive or confidential information in case exercises.

Academic Integrity

Submit original work, cite sources appropriately, and follow the academic integrity expectations described on the course site.

Tentative Schedule

Weeks 1-2	Health administration roles and the U.S. health care system
Weeks 3-4	Hospitals, ambulatory care, long-term care, and public health
Weeks 5-6	Insurance, reimbursement, access, and health care finance basics
Weeks 7-8	Operations, staffing, workflow, and service delivery
Weeks 9-10	Quality improvement, patient safety, and patient experience
Weeks 11-12	Health law, ethics, equity, and organizational decision-making
Weeks 13-14	Leadership, health policy, and strategic planning
Week 15	Final presentations and course reflection